

IBR Class Outline:

**Italy – Milan and Turin
(Summer 2026)**

UCLA Instructor: [Professor Nico Voigtländer](#)

Course Objectives and Outline

This course takes students to the most vibrant city in Italy: Milan, and to a true gem in the foothills of the Alps: Turin.

The course will provide you with an understanding of Italy's economic and business environment, with a focus on the economically most advanced area around Milan (Lombardy).

We will address topics such as

- The current economic and political environment in Italy, and prevailing trends
- How to do business in Italy and the opportunities for US business entities
- Challenges that the Italian economy faces due to globalization, digital transformation, and demographic change
- The current state of entrepreneurship and innovation in Milan, Italy and Europe
- An appreciation of Italian business and cultural norms
- The major sectors and companies in Italy (especially in the Milan area); the sectors include fashion, tourism, architecture, finance, food processing, and automotive

While in Italy, industry speakers, company tours, and visits to important cultural and historical locations will augment the topics covered in class. We will also spend a half day with faculty and students at SDA Bocconi, the leading business school in Italy, to hear lectures by their outstanding faculty, and to network with their EMBA students at a reception hosted by SDA Bocconi.

Course Structure

Pre- and post- classes (via Zoom). There will be 3 class sessions via Zoom (see content of these sessions below). Tentatively, these sessions are scheduled as follows:

- (1) July 26, 2026 – Sunday, 9am-12pm (Pacific Time)
- (2) August 23, 2026 – Sunday, 9am-12pm (Pacific Time)
- (3) October 4, 2026 – Sunday, 6pm-8pm (Post-travel)

The pre-travel classes will provide the foundation for the in-country portion of the course, focusing on Italy's business environment. The final post-travel class session will be used to examine the knowledge gleaned while in Italy and to synthesize all of the material covered in the course.

Zoom Link: <https://ucla.zoom.us/j/92114014674?pwd=McfNL44dvkbbajgYkv7dVSZtEZQhco.1>

Meeting ID: 921 1401 4674

Passcode: 247147

Milan/Turin: The in-country portion of the course will take place from **September 6-12, 2026**. A local sightseeing will take place in Milan in the afternoon of September 6, so students should arrive that day (but participation in the tour is not mandatory). Academic sessions will begin on Sep 7 in the morning. A draft schedule is included below; an updated daily schedule of the week in Italy will be provided at a later date.

Schedule Overview

	Location	Pre-Travel Zoom Class dates	In-Country (these dates are set)	Post-Travel Online Class date
	Milan / Turin Italy Summer/Fall 2026	Sun, Jul 26, 9am-12pm Sun, Aug 23, 9am-12pm	Sep 6-12, 2026 (Milan and Turin)	Sun., Oct 4, 6pm-8pm

Teaching Assistant (TA)

Teaching assistant for the course will be [Elisabetta Campagna](#), a PhD student in Anderson's Global Economic and Management Program.

Attendance Policy

Zoom classes. Please note that attendance is mandatory at all Zoom classes except by special permission from the instructor (via the TA). In special situations (e.g., medical or family emergencies), permission to “miss” Zoom sessions may be granted by the TA. The TA will record attendance – if you anticipate you have to miss a class, contact the TA ahead of time and state your reasons. The TA will confirm (and in the unlikely case that you cannot come to an agreement with the TA, you may contact the instructor).

Sessions in Milan/Turin. Attendance at all scheduled events while in Italy is mandatory.

Course Grade

The course grade will be determined as follows:

Quiz about 2 cases (individual homework before the first class)	10%
Short student video presentations (group basis)	25%
Individual participation (including active participation during trip)	25%
Final individual report (see detail at the end of this syllabus)	40%

The **final individual report** will be due at the beginning of the last Zoom class session on Oct 4, 2026. You will be allowed to pick from (at least) two topics to write an (approximately) 6-8 page report (max 1.5 margin, plus graphs and tables). These two topics are:

- (1) The likely future path of the Italian economy overall and
- (2) The future of the economy in and around Milan (or Turin).

Importantly, for each topic you will be asked to refer extensively to examples covered in class and specific knowledge learned during the visit to Italy. This is so we can distinguish your essay from an A.I.-generated text.

Zoom Class Sessions: Tentative content

As noted above, there are three Zoom class sessions, two occurring before the trip and one following the trip. The first two Zoom sessions will provide us with important background information and a framework for examining and analyzing the various facets of our visit in Italy. The third class session will enable us to synthesize the information and lessons learned throughout the course.

Date	Topic	Description
July 26, 2026 (Sunday), 9am – 12pm	Introduction to the Italian Economy	During this session, the instructor will give an overview about historical and cultural features that are central to understanding the world of business in Italy. Themes will include the economic history of Italy, the unification in the 19 th Century, as well as the current

		macroeconomic environment and Italy's political economy.
Aug 23, 2026 (Sunday) 9am – 12pm	Group presentations and discussions	In preparation for this class, student groups will record video presentations on different topics about the Italian economy and the Milan/Turin region. Each topic will have a "pro" and a "contra" group, arguing opposite points. Everybody watches all presentations in preparation for this class. During the Zoom class, one member of each group will present the executive summary of their video presentation, followed by Q&A and a discussion.
Oct 4, 2026 (Sunday) 6pm – 8pm	Debrief and Scenarios	The various lessons from the class sessions and the in-country portion of the course will be analyzed and synthesized. Information drawn from students' reports on the likely future path of the Italian economy will enhance the discussion.

Some more detail on the **group presentations**:

- During the first class, the instructor will introduce the presentation topics
- Students sign up into groups for each presentation topic
- Group size will be 4-6 students.
- Each group will tape a 5-10 minute video (strict time limit!) **by Aug 17, 2026.**
- Everybody will be required to watch the videos before class and prepare questions for the in-class Q&A and discussion during class time.
- In the class **on Aug 23**, each group will get 2 minutes to present their executive summary. This will be followed by a Q&A session and discussion.

About the Instructor

Nico Voigtländer joined the Global Economics and Management Group at UCLA Anderson in 2008. His main areas of research — long-run economic growth, political economy and economic history — provide him with the tools needed to understand how economic growth works “as a prerequisite to addressing important questions, such as poverty, inequality and the transition to ‘clean’ growth,” he explains. His most recent projects focus on the transition from stagnation to growth and why this structural break occurred first in Europe. He has also co-authored seminal contributions addressing the deep roots of anti-Semitism and on the rise of the Nazi Party in Germany. Another line of research investigates production networks, in particular how input-output relationships form and how they create multiplier effects that augment economic shocks.

As an academic, Voigtländer has taught microeconomics, economic growth and development economics at the graduate and undergraduate levels at UCLA, Harvard, and University College London. Voigtländer earned his Ph.D. in economics from Universitat Pompeu Fabra in Barcelona, Spain, the last year of which he was invited to UC Berkeley, as a visiting

researcher. In addition to his academic experience, Voigtländer worked as an associate for McKinsey & Co. and as a consultant to the German Stock Exchange. He has been a guest speaker and panelist at numerous national and international conferences, covering topics that range from the effects of trade on firm productivity to the role of highway building in the rise of Hitler to Nazi Germany's dictator. He is fluent in a number of languages, including German, Spanish, French and Italian and can get by in Catalan.